

Caribou

Rangifer tarandus

Description: The caribou is a member of the deer family found across the North American and Eurasian Arctic (where it is known as the reindeer). Its name comes from the Mi'kmaq Native American term *xalibú*, meaning "the one who paws." This likely stems from the way caribou paw at the snow to feed on the lichen beneath. In terms of physical characteristics, caribou possess the largest antlers of any deer species (up to 135 cm). They are the only deer species in which both males and females grow antlers; these are shed in early winter and regrow in the spring. In North America, herds can number up to hundreds of thousands of individuals.

Threats: Habitat destruction and the disruption of migratory routes caused by mining and oil operations. Rising temperatures in the Arctic lead to precipitation falling as rain rather than snow; when this rain freezes, it creates an ice layer that prevents caribou from accessing lichen and feeding during the winter. Warmer summers bring an increase in parasite populations, which can severely affect caribou health. Over the past 25 years, the global population has declined by 40%, with some herds experiencing a dramatic drop of more than 90%. This decline also poses a threat to Indigenous peoples whose lives are closely linked to the caribou.

Conservation status (IUCN): vulnerable

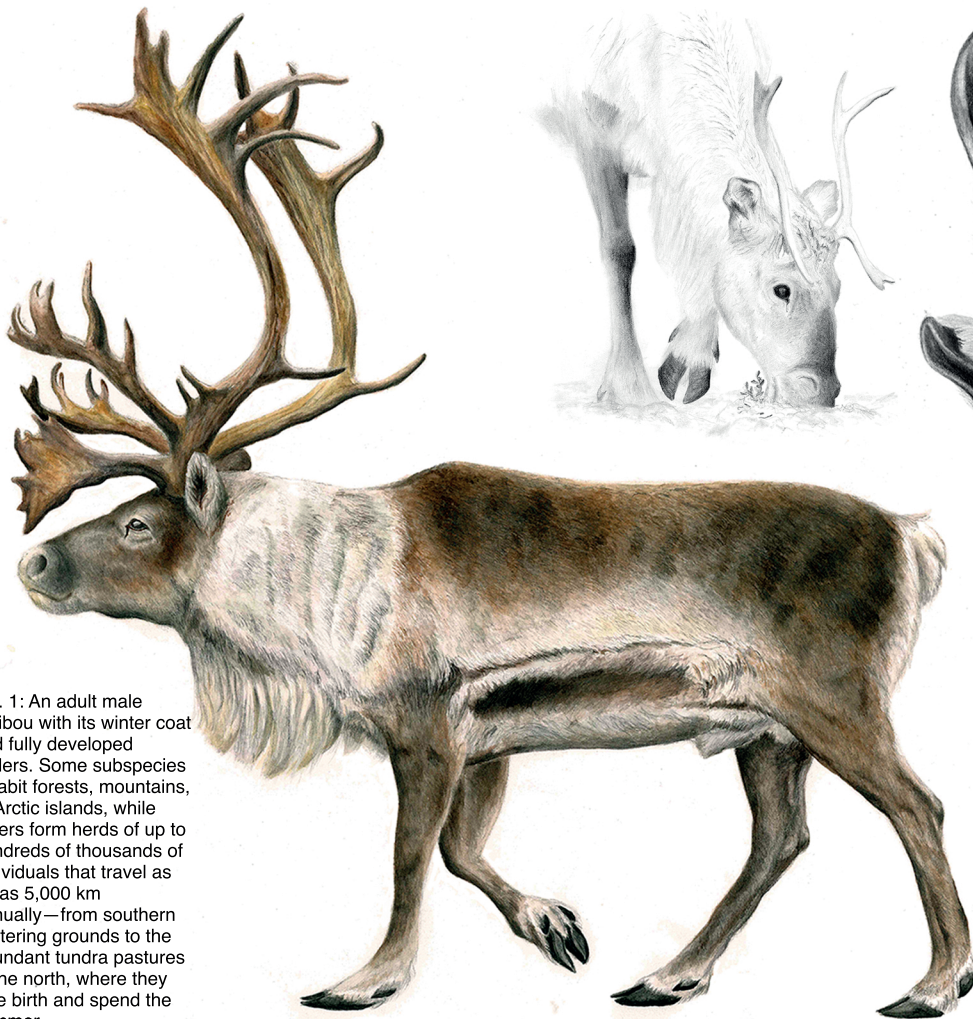


Fig. 1: An adult male caribou with its winter coat and fully developed antlers. Some subspecies inhabit forests, mountains, or Arctic islands, while others form herds of up to hundreds of thousands of individuals that travel as far as 5,000 km annually—from southern wintering grounds to the abundant tundra pastures in the north, where they give birth and spend the summer.

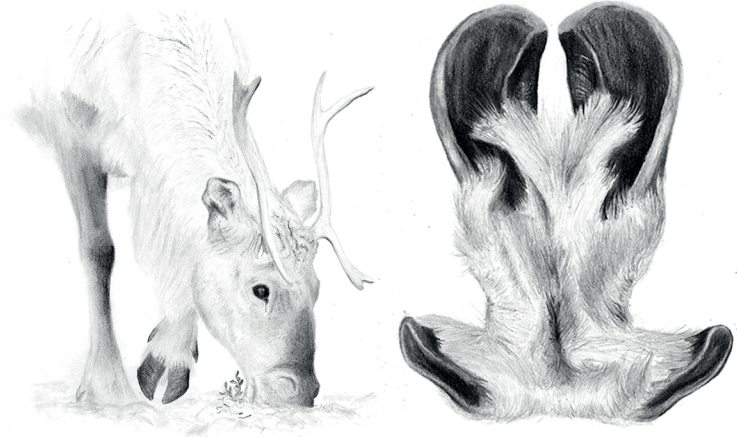


Fig. 2: Caribou hooves are covered in fur, insulating the skin from the frozen ground. When the animal steps down, the hooves spread wide, allowing it to walk on snow and swim with ease. Their concave shape and sharp edges make them effective tools for digging through the snow to feed on lichens.